

Islamophobia Spreads Fast, As Does Fear

Mosque Attack Reflects Rise in Overt Hatred

By SHAILA DEWAN and JILL COWAN

The young men who killed three people outside a San Diego mosque complex this week had expressed hatred for all types of people, inspired by vitriol and conspiracy theories they found online, law enforcement officials said. But it was Muslims they chose to target.

To some, the killings seemed like an inevitable result of a swell of Islamophobia in the United States and around the globe. Anti-Muslim rhetoric on the right has become louder, with Republican politicians raising concerns about new Muslim schools and growing Muslim communities, and, at the most extreme, suggesting Muslims don't belong here.

Muslema Purmul, 43, whose children attended school on the mosque campus, said her 12-year-old son was feeling gloomy, angry and sad. "Then he said something that really hurt us," Ms. Purmul said, her voice breaking. "He said, 'I feel unwanted.'"

Ms. Purmul, a longtime member of the community who knew all three of the shooting victims, said that her son had gone on to observe, "If this were to happen to anyone else, everyone would make a much bigger deal about it."

Hatred against Muslims is a longstanding problem. But the escalating conflict between Arabs and Jews in the Middle East, the war in Iran, and the reverberations of both throughout American politics have ushered in a new phase of overt discrimination and fears of violence. Politicians like Representative Randy Fine of Florida have enthusiastically embraced Islamophobia, saying it is rational and more of it is needed.

President Trump himself has a history of criticizing Muslims and Islam, and has recently posted about the war in Iran in inflammatory terms, including a message on Easter in which he promised that "a whole civilization will die." In another message he signed off, "praise be to Allah."

This week, Laura Loomer, an adviser to President Trump, suggested on social media that all Muslims should be deported and called them an "invasive species."

Her remarks showed how mainstream Islamophobia had become, said Nader Hashemi, the director of the Alwaleed Center for Muslim-Christian Understanding

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DOUG MILLS/THE NEW YORK TIMES

\$1.8 Billion Fund Uses Mechanism Long Seen as Ripe for Abuse

By ADAM LIPTAK

WASHINGTON — In January, on a flight to his Florida club Mar-a-Lago, President Trump mused about his \$10 billion lawsuit against the I.R.S. "I'm supposed to work out a settlement with myself," he said.

Mr. Trump is a tough negotiator, and, looking in the mirror, he faced an equally tenacious adversary. But the president managed to work out a deal with himself on Monday, one as novel and brazen as the process that spawned it.

He dropped his lawsuit, extracting from his own government a promise to create a \$1.8 billion fund to dole out to his political allies. A day later, in a curious addendum, Todd Blanche, Mr. Trump's former lawyer and the acting attorney general, purported to immunize him from lawsuits arising from a great many things, not least his tax liabilities.

The government of the United States, Mr. Blanche wrote, is "forever barred and precluded" from pursuing claims against Mr. Trump involving "lawfare and/or weaponization" or tax returns.

The whole enterprise was a jarring shock to the conventional understanding of the constitutional system, raising what legal experts said were profound questions about presidential power. If the arrangement is allowed to stand, they said, Mr. Trump will have managed simultaneously to thwart Congress's power of the purse and the ability of the courts to police the separation of powers.

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U.S. Charges Raúl Castro In 1996 Downing of Planes

Indictment of Cuban Ex-Leader Could Lead to Military Action to Capture Him

This article is by Alan Feuer, Frances Robles and David C. Adams.

The Justice Department announced charges on Wednesday against Raúl Castro, the 94-year-old former president of Cuba, accusing him of murder and a conspiracy to kill American citizens stemming from the fatal downing 30 years ago of two planes over waters off the coast of his country.

The indictment, issued in Federal District Court in Miami, was an extraordinary escalation of the Trump administration's multifaceted pressure campaign against Cuba's Communist government at a moment when President Trump has been seeking to topple it.

The charges brought to bear on Mr. Castro, the brother of Fidel Castro, the vast powers of the U.S. criminal justice system, saddling him with a possible maximum penalty of life in prison. They also raised the possibility that the United States could be paving the way for its military to remove him from the country through a means similar to how U.S. Special Operations forces used an indictment against Nicolás Maduro, the former leader of Venezuela, to swoop into Caracas in a brazen operation in January and capture him.

The indictment, which also accused five fighter pilots involved in the attack on the planes, was secretly returned last month by a federal grand jury and built on earlier charges, first filed in 2003, against one of them.

At a news conference in Miami, the acting attorney general, Todd Blanche, and Jason A. Reding Quiñones, the U.S. attorney for the Southern District of Florida, accused Mr. Castro and the pilots of killing four people when the Cuban military shot down the planes on the afternoon of Feb. 24, 1996. The planes were operated by Brothers to the Rescue, a Cuban exile group that often scoured the seas for Cubans fleeing the country.

Fidel Castro took responsibility for downing the planes shortly after they were brought from the sky, claiming that the organization had been dropping anti-regime leaflets over Havana in earlier flights. The indictment said that



ADALBERTO ROQUE/A.F.P. — GETTY IMAGES
Raúl Castro in 2006. Cuba's former president is now 94.

Raúl Castro was also responsible because he and his brother were "the final decision makers" in the Cuban military chain of command.

Mr. Blanche portrayed the charges against Mr. Castro as a historic step toward holding the leaders of Cuba's government accountable for its past wrongs.

"My message today is clear," he said. "The United States and President Trump does not — and will not — forget its citizens."

Mr. Blanche sidestepped questions

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Trump's Success In Revenge Tour May Hurt in Fall

By SHANE GOLDMACHER

The defeat of Representative Thomas Massie on Tuesday served as an emphatic exclamation point on an extraordinary three-week vengeance tour that displayed President Trump's enduring sway over his own party.

Yet Mr. Trump's viselike hold on the Republican base — a full decade after he locked up his first presidential nomination — poses a distinct conundrum for the party ahead of the fall's critical midterms. He has appeared more keen to leverage his popularity with the MAGA base to oust wayward Republicans than to repair his image among the independents his party will need to defeat Democrats this fall.

For years, Mr. Trump has imposed party discipline by electoral force. His message to any Republicans considering breaking with him in 2026 is unmistakable: Cross me at your peril.

The example making being in Indiana, where Mr. Trump recruited challengers who ousted five state senators who had refused to succumb to his pressure to draw new congressional districts in the state more favorable to the G.O.P. It continued in Louisiana, where Senator Bill Cassidy, who voted five years ago to convict Mr. Trump during his second impeachment trial, won a measly 25 percent of the vote in his reelection run, failing even to advance to a runoff after the president threw his weight behind a challenger.

It concluded on Tuesday in Kentucky, where Mr. Massie, one of

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ARASH KHAMOUSHI/POLARIS FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES
A plan to install Mahmoud Ahmadinejad soon went awry.

The Hard-Liner The U.S. Eyed As Iran's Leader

This article is by Mark Mazzetti, Julian E. Barnes, Farnaz Fassihi and Ronen Bergman.

WASHINGTON — Days after Israeli strikes killed Iran's supreme leader and other top officials in the opening salvos of the war, President Trump mused publicly that it would be best if "someone from within" Iran took over the country.

It turns out that the United States and Israel went into the conflict with a particular and very surprising someone in mind: Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, the former Iranian president known for his hard-line, anti-Israel and anti-American views.

But the audacious plan, developed by the Israelis and which Mr. Ahmadinejad had been consulted about, quickly went awry, according to the U.S. officials who were briefed on it.

Mr. Ahmadinejad was injured on the war's first day by an Israeli strike on his home in Tehran that had been designed to free him

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BARNEY FRANK, 1940-2026

Gay Pioneer and Liberal Hero Who Plied Acid Wit in House

By KATHARINE Q. SEELYE

Barney Frank, the brassy, lightning-quick former Massachusetts representative who for decades was the most prominent gay politician in the country and who was an author of the most significant overhaul of the nation's financial regulations since the Great Depression, died on Tuesday at his home in Ogunquit, Maine. He was 86.

His friend James Segel confirmed the death. Mr. Frank said last month that he had entered hospice care with congestive heart failure.

Mr. Frank, a liberal Democrat who represented a diverse suburban Boston district for 32 years, starting in 1981, was the first gay member of the House to come out voluntarily; others had been outed in scandals. His public declaration of his sexual orientation in 1987 — spurred by a fear of being outed, by the death of a closeted colleague and by his own determination to show that homosexuality was nothing to be ashamed of — helped normalize being openly gay in public life.

"Prejudice is based on ignorance," Mr. Frank told The Boston Globe in 2011, as he prepared to retire. "And the best way to counterbalance it is with a living example, with reality."

A Harvard-trained lawyer, Mr. Frank bristled with intellectual firepower, acidic turns of phrase and a zest for verbal combat.

His shivs were often cloaked in wit. Referring to the Moral Majority, the conservative Christian organization that opposed abortion but also opposed child nutrition programs and day care, Mr. Frank said in 1981: "From their perspective, life begins at conception and

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BRENDAN SMIALOWSKI FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

Barney Frank was the first House member to come out voluntarily.

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It's taken years to prosecute a French official who has admitted slipping diuretics into women's drinks. PAGE A4

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